

performance. Later that year, Ravel was admitted to the Conservatoire to study piano. But it was as a composer rather than a pianist that his real talent lay, and while he was at the Conservatoire he began writing music in earnest. One of the events that inspired this change of emphasis was the 1889 Exposition Universelle in Paris, where he was exposed to exciting new and unfamiliar music.

Through the 1890s, Ravel focused on composition, but at the expense of his studies—his lack of progress in piano and theory obliged him to leave the Conservatoire in 1895. However, he enrolled in a composition course there two years later. His teacher, Gabriel Fauré, recognized his talent. Under his guidance, Ravel gained confidence to write his first mature works. He was also inspired by Erik Satie, whom he had met, and by his unconventional approach to composition. Ravel resolved to compose in the way he felt most comfortable, impervious to criticism.



SET DESIGN, *DAPHNIS ET CHLOE*

This set design was commissioned by Sergei Diaghilev for the Ballets Russes'